



UKRAINE

Capital city: Kiev

Area: 223,090 sq miles
(603,700 sq km)

Population: 47,700,000

Official language:
Ukrainian

Major religions: Majority
of population is Christian

Government: Multiparty
democracy

Currency: Hryvna

Adult literacy rate: 77%

Life expectancy: 75 years

People per doctor: 556

Televisions: 490 per 1,000
people

MOLDOVA

Capital city: Chisinau

Area: 13,067 sq miles
(33,843 sq kms)

Population: 4,300,000

Official language:
Moldovan

Major religions: Christian
99%, Jewish 1%

Government: Multiparty
democracy

Currency: Moldovan leu

Adult literacy rate: 99%

Life expectancy: 67 years

People per doctor: 370

Televisions: 297 per 1,000
people

UKRAINE

WITH ITS VAST, FERTILE PLAINS and huge coal resources, Ukraine could be one of the most powerful countries of the former USSR. Following independence in 1991, relations with the Russian Federation were poor, because the two countries disagreed over ownership of weapons and ships belonging to the former USSR. Ethnic tension is a problem, too, as one in five of the population is Russian. In 1986, the world's worst nuclear accident, at the Chernobyl nuclear power plant, contaminated a huge area, affecting people, animals, and even the soil.

Kiev is situated on the Dnieper River, Ukraine's main waterway.



KIEV

Ukraine's capital city has been overrun repeatedly by powerful invaders. In the 9th century, it was the center of a trading empire founded by the Vikings. It was invaded by the Mongols, and then by the Polish-Lithuanian Empire in the 14th century. In the 17th century, Kiev fell to the Russian Empire, later to become part of the USSR. Heavily bombed in World War II, Kiev was rebuilt in the 1950s-1960s and is now a center for communications, culture, and education.



HEAVY INDUSTRY

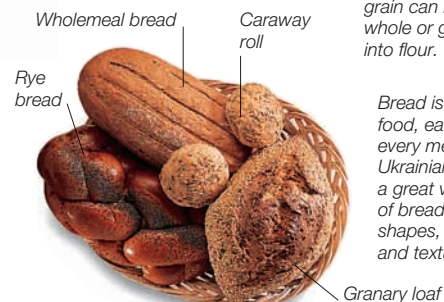
The Donbass Basin in eastern Ukraine is Europe's largest coalfield. It is also a major industrial area, with local coal and hydroelectricity powering one of the world's largest iron and steel industries. Factories process metals into finished products, including ships and machinery. However, many mines and factories are inefficient and new investment is needed.

CEREAL CROPS

Almost three-quarters of Ukraine is covered by fertile plains known as steppes. Much of this land is used to grow cereals. The huge quantities of wheat, corn, barley, oats, buckwheat, and rye Ukraine produces earned it the title "bread basket of the Soviet Union." However, farmers are not realizing the land's full potential due to a lack of new technology.



Grains of cereal grow on the ears of each plant. This grain can be eaten whole or ground into flour.



Bread is the main food, eaten with every meal. Ukrainians bake a great variety of bread in all shapes, sizes, and textures.

MOLDOVA

THIS SMALL, RURAL country was part of Romania before being taken over by the USSR in 1940. Although it is the most densely populated republic of the former USSR, native Moldovians make up fewer than two-thirds of the population. After independence ethnic unrest broke out and minority groups including Russians and Ukrainians wanted independence. Although there is now peace, tensions still remain.



Most of the population lives in country areas and makes a living from small-scale farming.

AGRICULTURE

Moldova's fertile soil and mild climate allow a variety of crops to be grown, such as corn, sunflower seeds, tobacco, and vines. Much of the produce is exported to countries of the former USSR to raise cash for vital imports such as oil - Moldova has few mineral resources of its own. Industries related to farming, such as food processing, are important, too.

Find out more

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